

AI-Driven Financial Analysis: \$433K Identified in 48 Hours

How Claude AI + NetSuite data + operational spreadsheets uncovered ~\$433,000 in financial waste and lost revenue across a 50-person experiential marketing agency.

Agency	RedPeg Marketing (50-person experiential agency)
Role	AI Lead, working directly with CFO
Timeline	2-day analysis sprint, March 2026
AI Tools	Claude (Anthropic), NetSuite data connection, Excel/CSV analysis
Classification	Confidential internal analysis (names and clients redacted for portfolio use)

~\$433K Total Financial Impact	~2,887 Hours Impacted	1.4 FTEs Full-Year Equivalent
\$193K Over-Delivery Loss	\$165K Unsigned Exposure	\$113K Wasted Admin Capacity

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

What Claude Found

This analysis identifies approximately \$433,000 in financial waste and lost revenue across three categories: over-delivery on signed client work (\$193K), hours burned on unsigned and pending engagements (\$165K), and excess administrative time consuming billable capacity (\$113K).

Combined, these issues represent ~2,887 hours, the equivalent of 1.4 full-time employees working for an entire year. The root causes are distinct but related: weak scope management, a contract process that allows work to start without signatures, and operational habits that have not kept pace with the agency's growth.

The AI Process

Ryan partnered with the CFO to run this analysis using Claude as the primary analytical engine. The process:

1. Connected Claude to NetSuite financial data (actuals vs. scoped hours, YTD 2026)
2. Fed in operational spreadsheets covering staffing, project assignments, and billing rates
3. Claude cross-referenced hours logged against contracted scope across every active engagement
4. Identified patterns: which employees were consistently over-delivering, which clients had unsigned contracts with active work, and which staff had disproportionate admin-to-billable ratios
5. Generated a comprehensive analysis with dollar values, root cause diagnosis, and strategic recommendations

Total elapsed time from data ingestion to finished report: approximately 48 hours. A traditional consulting engagement covering this scope would typically require 2-4 weeks and cost \$30K-\$80K.

SECTION 1

Free Work Being Given Away: ~\$320,000

Free work takes two forms: hours delivered beyond the contracted scope (over-delivery) and hours invested in clients who have not yet signed a contract. Both represent real cost with no guaranteed recovery. Together they account for the majority of the identified financial waste.

A. Over-Delivery on Signed Work: \$193,194

Work delivered beyond contracted scope, either through under-scoping at the proposal stage or staff exceeding authorized hours during delivery. Every hour in this category is revenue earned but not billed.

Employee	Hours Over Scope	Dollar Value
[REDACTED]	186 hrs	\$30,342
[REDACTED]	142 hrs	\$22,894
[REDACTED]	135 hrs	\$20,837
[REDACTED]	110 hrs	\$18,630
[REDACTED]	108 hrs	\$15,399
[REDACTED]	84 hrs	\$14,027
[REDACTED]	81 hrs	\$11,765
[REDACTED]	66 hrs	\$9,433
[REDACTED]	48 hrs	\$7,738
[REDACTED]	37 hrs	\$7,362
[REDACTED]	35 hrs	\$6,235
[REDACTED]	33 hrs	\$6,078
[REDACTED]	26 hrs	\$5,528
[REDACTED]	36 hrs	\$4,101
[REDACTED]	22 hrs	\$3,831
TOTAL	--	\$193,194

Note: Dollar values calculated using each employee's implied billing rate (scoped revenue / scoped hours). Names redacted for confidentiality.

B. Unsigned Client Work: ~\$107,700 (718 Hours)

Hours burned on clients who have not signed a contract. This is pure exposure. If the deal falls through, none of this time is recoverable.

Client	Status	Hours	Estimated Value
██████████	UNSIGNED	425 hrs	~\$63,750
██████████	UNSIGNED	293 hrs	~\$43,950
TOTAL		718 hrs	~\$107,700

C. Pending Work (High Risk): ~\$57,300 at Risk

Two major client engagements are still PENDING, not signed. 382 hours have already been logged, representing ~\$57,300 in at-risk revenue. This is the most acute near-term exposure because the team is actively working and the clock is running.

Employee	Hours Logged (Pending Clients)
██████████	150 hrs
██████████	128 hrs
██████████	60 hrs
██████████	31 hrs
██████████	8 hrs
██████████	5 hrs
TOTAL	382 hrs = ~\$57,300 at risk

SECTION 2

Wasted Capacity: Excess Admin Time (~\$113,100)

Admin hours are necessary, but at a certain level they represent billable hours consumed by internal work. Using the agency's most senior staff member as a benchmark for appropriate overhead, Claude identified staff who significantly exceed that threshold. The dollar figures represent the cost of hours not deployed on client work.

Employee	Admin Hrs	Excess vs. Benchmark	Wasted Capacity \$
██████████	352 hrs	+226 hrs	\$33,900
██████████	263 hrs	+137 hrs	\$20,550
██████████	252 hrs	+126 hrs	\$18,900
██████████	239 hrs	+113 hrs	\$16,950
██████████	208 hrs	+82 hrs	\$12,300
██████████	196 hrs	+70 hrs	\$10,500
TOTAL	--	~754 hrs	~\$113,100

BOTTOM LINE

Summary of Findings

Problem Category	Root Cause	Dollar Impact
Over-delivery on signed work	Scope/delivery management	\$193,194
Unsigned + pending client work	Contract/sales process	\$165,000
Excess admin time	Operational efficiency	\$113,100
TOTAL IDENTIFIED WASTE		~\$433,000

~\$433,000 in lost revenue and wasted capacity represents approximately 2,887 hours, the equivalent of 1.4 FTEs working full-time for an entire year.

What This Demonstrates

This analysis was not a technology demo. It was a real financial audit that surfaced findings the agency's leadership team acted on. Here is what it proves about AI applied to business operations:

Speed: A 2-day analysis that would have taken a consulting firm 2-4 weeks. Claude ingested financial data, cross-referenced it against contracts and staffing plans, and produced a structured diagnostic with dollar values attached to every finding.

Depth: This was not a surface-level summary. Claude identified individual-level patterns: which staff members were consistently over-delivering, which clients had the most unsigned exposure, which team members' admin-to-billable ratios indicated structural role problems. The analysis went employee-by-employee, client-by-client.

Strategic framing: Claude did not just produce numbers. The analysis included root cause diagnosis (scope management, contract process, operational habits) and strategic recommendations. The report was written to be actionable, not just informational.

CFO partnership: Ryan did not run this in isolation. He worked directly with the CFO, who provided the data and validated the findings. This is AI as a force multiplier for existing leadership, not a replacement.

Immediate ROI: The cost of the AI tools used for this analysis was negligible (standard Claude subscription). The findings represent a potential 433x return if even a fraction of the identified waste is addressed.

Additional AI-Built Tools at RedPeg

This cost-savings analysis is one component of a broader AI transformation Ryan led at RedPeg. Other tools built with Claude include:

- **Morning Briefing Dashboard:** An automated HTML dashboard that pulls live data from Asana, Slack, and calendar systems to produce a VP-level daily standup view. Surfaces urgent items, OOO/travel status, and client channel activity in one place.
- **Utilization Report Dashboard:** An interactive HTML tool (built with the CFO) that visualizes employee utilization across billable, non-billable, and admin time. Includes filtering by department, client, and date range with drill-down modals for individual employees.
- **AI Onboarding System:** A three-part system (custom Claude skill, onboarding website, PDF playbook) that took RedPeg from zero AI adoption to daily usage across the team.